

AMERICAN ICON

The bald eagle, whose name derives from the conspicuous appearance of its white-feathered head, has been the national bird of the USA since 1782. The only eagle solely native to North America, the bald eagle has been a protected species since 1940.

*Haliaeetus leucocephalus***Bald eagle****Location** North America**Length** 28–38 in
(71–96 cm)**Weight** 6½–14 lb
(3–6.5 kg)**Plumage** Sexes similar**Migration** Partial migrant**Status** Least concern

The majestic bald eagle is a large, powerfully built bird, with a wingspan of up to 8¼ft (2.5 m). Although often found well away from water when wintering, bald eagles are commonly seen close to lakes, rivers, and coastal areas, where they have ample access to fish. Bald eagles pair for life, and while sedentary birds stay together throughout the year, those that migrate

separate then come together again at breeding sites. They reinforce their pair bond through often spectacular flight displays involving undulating flight, swooping at one another, and cart-wheeling through the air with clasped feet. Together, they build a very large nest (in a tree or sometimes on the ground), reaching up to 13 ft (4 m) tall. Bald eagles start to breed at about 5 years of age, and usually 2 or 3 eggs are laid. Although the young are cared for by both parents for many weeks, a high percentage do not survive their first year.

**DISTINCTIVE FEATURES**

The bald eagle is easily spotted by its pure white head and tail, its broad, brown-black wings, and its large, yellow bill. Juveniles take up to 5 years to gain full adult plumage.

FEEDING HABITS

The bald eagle takes food from a range of sources, live and dead, including small birds, carrion (especially during the winter months), and fish. When hunting for fish, it does not usually enter the water like the osprey (see p.296), but instead searches for dead or dying fish or those that live near the surface.

FISHING TECHNIQUE

The bald eagle uses its strong feet equipped with sharp claws to snatch fish from the water's surface.

**FOOD FIGHT**

As well as piratically stealing food from other predatory birds such as ospreys, bald eagles often fight between themselves over prey items.

WINTER DIET

In winter, bald eagles sometimes collect in large groups close to where salmon come to spawn.

